

Chapter —

GCE O Level English Language 1184

Paper 2 — Question Type Directory and Technique Guide

This guide has two parts. **Part 1** is the Question Type Directory: it lists every question type tested in Sections B and C, assigns it a memorable tag, and directs you to the answering technique required. **Part 2** is the Technique Guide: it provides the full method, sentence-structure templates, and common pitfalls for each of the six techniques. Learn a technique once and apply it wherever the tag directs you.

Exam workflow: Read the question → identify the signal words → find the tag → apply the technique.

How to read the Directory

Tag	Question type	Signal words	Technique	Original code
LIFT	Literal / Factual Recall	State, Give, What, Find, Where, Who, When	SCAN	<i>B1, C1</i>

Original codes refer to SEAB Syllabus 1184 question-type labels and are provided for cross-reference with school papers only.

Chapter 1

Question Type Directory

Read the question → find the tag → go to the technique

The table below lists all twenty question types tested in Sections B and C. Each type is assigned a short, descriptive tag that names the core task. Use the signal words to identify the question type, then apply the technique shown.

Tag	Question type	Signal words and patterns	Technique	Orig.
LIFT	Literal / Factual Recall	State..., Give..., What did..., Where..., Who..., When..., Find one detail...	SCAN	B1, C1
SPOT	Physical Evidence	Give two examples of physical evidence that show..., Find evidence that the character was [emotion]...	SCAN	B2
FIND	Word / Phrase Identification	Identify one word..., Find a phrase..., Which group of words in Paragraph X suggests...	SCAN	B14
INFER	Inference	What does this suggest..., What does this imply..., What do you think..., Why do you think...	DEDUCE	B4, C3
TRAIT	Character Impression	What impression do you get of [character]..., What does this tell us about the sort of person [character] is...	DEDUCE	B9
MINDSET	State of Mind / Reaction	What does the phrase [X] tell us about [character's] reaction...	DEDUCE	B12
STANCE	Writer's Attitude	What is the writer's attitude towards..., What does the writer think about... (non-fiction)	DEDUCE	C4
DEFINE	Vocabulary in Context	Explain the meaning of the word / phrase [X] as used in..., What does [X] mean in this context...	SWAP	B5, C2
REPHRASE	In Your Own Words / Paraphrase	Explain in your own words..., Use your own words to explain...	SWAP	B6, C10
EFFECT	Use of Language for Effect	Explain how the language in Paragraph X [creates / makes / suggests]..., Support your answer with two details...	QEE	B7, C7
ODDWORD	Unusual and Effective	What is (i) unusual and (ii) effective about the phrase [X]...	QEE	B8
TONE	Tone of Voice	What is the tone of [speaker's] comment..., Give one word.	QEE	B10, C6
MOOD	Mood / Atmosphere	What mood is created in Paragraph X..., Support with one word or phrase.	QEE	B11

CRAFT	Technical Writer's Craft	What effect does the writer create by using [technique] in lines X–Y..., How does the writer achieve [effect]...	QEE	<i>B15</i>
QUOTES	Inverted Commas / Scare Quotes	Why do you think the writer puts inverted commas around [word]...	QEE	<i>C5</i>
PROVE	Three-Piece Evidence Explanation	Explain how this claim is supported with reference to three pieces of evidence from Paragraph X...	BUILD	<i>B3</i>
CONTRAST	Identify the Contrast	What is the contrast between [A] and [B] in Paragraph X...	BUILD	<i>B13</i>
DEFEND	Justification Question	How could [party] justify [claim]..., With reference to Paragraph X, how could [party] argue that...	BUILD	<i>C8</i>
DEBATE	Two-Students Question	[Student A] says... [Student B] says... Using lines X–Y, explain whose view is better supported...	BUILD	<i>C11</i>
WHY/HOW	Why vs How Distinction	Why does the writer..., How does the writer..., Why is [X] included..., How is [effect] created...	WH-CHECK	<i>C9</i>

Technique Quick-Lookup

Technique	Core action	Applies to tags
SCAN	Locate the minimum accurate phrase within the named paragraph	LIFT · SPOT · FIND
DEDUCE	Read between the lines; express inference in own words, grounded in text	INFER · TRAIT · MINDSET · STANCE
SWAP	Substitute every key content word with a shade-equivalent synonym	DEFINE · REPHRASE
QEE	Quote (2–5 words) → Explain (different words) → link to Effect	EFFECT · ODDWORD · TONE · MOOD · CRAFT · QUOTES
BUILD	Select evidence + explain each piece + paraphrase throughout	PROVE · CONTRAST · DEFEND · DEBATE
WH-CHECK	Identify the question word first; match answer type to WHY or HOW	WHY/HOW · and as a discipline across all techniques

Original codes in italics are provided for cross-reference with SEAB syllabus documents and school papers only. Use the tags and technique names when studying with this sheet.

Chapter 2

Technique: SCAN

Used for: LIFT · SPOT · FIND

The SCAN technique is used whenever the question asks you to locate information that is explicitly stated in the passage. Nothing is hidden; the answer is on the page. Your task is to find the minimum accurate phrase within the named paragraph and reproduce it precisely. No inference or interpretation is required.

Key Rule — Excess Denied

If you copy a sentence that contains both the correct answer and any incorrect or irrelevant information, the entire answer is rejected. Always lift the smallest accurate phrase, not the surrounding sentence. This rule applies equally to LIFT, SPOT, and FIND.

Section A — LIFT — Literal / Factual Recall

LIFT questions ask you to find a stated fact or detail. The information is directly and explicitly present in the passage. Lifting (copying directly) is permitted; paraphrase is also acceptable. Where two details are required, each must be a genuinely separate piece of information.

Question Type: LIFT

Technique: Locate the named paragraph, scan for the exact information requested, and extract the minimum accurate phrase. Stop there.

- Step 1:** Identify the paragraph or line range named in the question.
- Step 2:** Scan only that range for the specific information requested.
- Step 3:** Select the smallest accurate phrase or clause.
- Step 4:** If two details are required, verify that each is genuinely distinct.
- Step 5:** Write your answer. Do not add explanation.

Worked Example 1

Signal words: *State one reason why... / Give two details from Paragraph 2...*

Locate the named paragraph. Find the clause that directly answers the question. Lift the minimum accurate phrase, placing it in inverted commas if copying directly.

One detail (lifted): "[Exact phrase from text]."

One detail (paraphrased): [Subject] [verb in own words] [object or location].

Two details: First, [detail 1]. Second, [detail 2].

Worked Example 2

Signal words: *What did the survey find? Give one detail.*

This is a LIFT question in a non-fiction (Section C) context. The same method applies. Non-fiction passages often embed the answer in a subordinate clause — identify the clause, not the full complex sentence.

Answer: "[Exact clause from the subordinate clause containing the finding]."

Common Pitfalls — LIFT

1. Answering from the wrong paragraph or outside the named line range.
2. Copying a full complex sentence when only a subordinate clause is needed — triggers Excess Denied.
3. Giving one detail when two are explicitly required.
4. Adding explanation — LIFT questions do not reward elaboration.

Section B — SPOT — Physical Evidence

SPOT questions ask you to find observable, physical evidence: actions, bodily reactions, or direct speech. Internal thoughts or stated emotions (e.g. 'she felt afraid') are not physical evidence and will not earn marks. Always use inverted commas when lifting. Do not explain unless the question asks you to.

Question Type: SPOT

Technique: Identify the number of physical details required, then scan the named paragraph for observable details only. Do not include internal states.

Step 1: Confirm how many physical details are required (usually two or three).

Step 2: Return to the named paragraph and scan for observable, physical details only.

Step 3: Select details that are genuinely distinct from one another.

Step 4: Present each detail separately, in inverted commas.

Step 5: Stop. Do not explain unless the question explicitly asks for it.

Worked Example 1

Signal words: *Give two examples of physical evidence from Paragraphs 3 and 4 that show the character was frightened.*

Scan Paragraphs 3 and 4 for observable physical details — things a bystander could see or hear. Exclude any sentences that state a feeling directly (e.g. 'he was terrified').

Single detail: "[Exact quotation]."

Two details: One example is "[detail 1]". Another example is "[detail 2]".

Three details: First, "[detail 1]". Second, "[detail 2]". Third, "[detail 3]".

Common Pitfalls — SPOT

1. Including an emotional statement ('she felt scared') when only physical evidence is asked for.
2. Selecting vague details that do not specifically support the claim in the question.
3. Giving the same detail reworded in two slightly different ways and treating them as separate answers.
4. Adding explanation when only evidence is required.

Section C — FIND — Word / Phrase Identification

FIND questions ask you to locate a single word, phrase, or group of words from the named paragraph that conveys a particular quality. Match the exact unit requested: if the question asks for a word, give one word. If it asks for a phrase, give a phrase. Always enclose your answer in inverted commas.

Question Type: FIND

Technique: Identify the unit of language required, scan the named paragraph for the best match, and reproduce it exactly.

Step 1: Confirm what unit is required: one word, a phrase, a group of words, or a sentence.

Step 2: Return to the named paragraph and read it with the question's stated quality in mind.

Step 3: Identify the word or phrase that most directly and precisely conveys that quality.

Step 4: Write your answer in inverted commas, exactly as it appears in the passage.

Step 5: Do not add explanation unless the question asks for it.

Worked Example 1

Signal words: *Identify one word in Paragraph 4 which suggests that Coach is surprised.*

Scan Paragraph 4 for a single word that carries the meaning of 'surprise'. Choose the word that most precisely conveys this — not the most obvious word, but the most accurate one.

One word: "[Single word from passage]."

Phrase: "[Exact phrase from passage]."

Common Pitfalls — FIND

1. Giving a sentence when a word is asked for — the extra words cannot earn marks even if the correct word is embedded in them.
2. Choosing a word from outside the named paragraph.
3. Omitting inverted commas around the quotation.
4. Choosing a related but less precise word when a more exact match exists in the paragraph.

Chapter 3

Technique: DEDUCE

Used for: INFER · TRAIT · MINDSET · STANCE

The DEDUCE technique is used whenever the question asks you to read between the lines. The answer is not directly stated; you must use evidence in the text to derive what is implied. If you can locate and copy the answer verbatim, you are answering a SCAN question, not a DEDUCE question. DEDUCE answers must always be expressed in your own words.

Four Terms You Must Distinguish

Term	Definition	Tag → Technique
Tone	Writer's or speaker's attitude as conveyed through word choice in a specific passage	TONE → use QEE
Mood	Emotional atmosphere created in the reader by the setting or scene	MOOD → use QEE
Attitude	Writer's stable, considered viewpoint towards a topic across the passage	STANCE → use DEDUCE
Feeling	A character's internal personal emotion at a specific moment	INFER, MINDSET → use DEDUCE

Section A — INFER — Inference

INFER questions ask you to deduce a character's thoughts, feelings, or situation — or the writer's implied viewpoint — from textual cues: description, action, dialogue, or figurative language. For two-mark questions, push to a second, deeper layer of meaning beyond the surface reading.

Question Type: INFER

Technique: Identify the inference signal word, read the named paragraph carefully, and express a logical conclusion in your own words, grounded in a specific textual cue.

Step 1: Underline the signal word in the question: suggest / imply / indicate / what do you think.

Step 2: Read the named paragraph slowly, noting word choice, actions, and figurative language.

Step 3: Ask: what is the writer not saying directly, but clearly meaning?

Step 4: Express your inference in your own words — do not lift.

Step 5: For two-mark questions, identify a second, deeper layer of meaning.

Worked Example 1

Signal words: *What does the description in Paragraph 4 suggest about how Mei felt about her son? Use your own words.*

Read Paragraph 4 slowly. Identify the specific word choice, action, or image that carries emotional meaning. Translate this into a statement about the character's inner state.

One mark: This suggests that [character] felt / was / believed [inference in own words].

Two marks: This suggests that [character] [inference 1 in own words], as [paraphrased evidence]. This further implies that [deeper inference].

Worked Example 2

Signal words: *How does the phrase 'under the shadow of technology' suggest the writer disapproves of technology? (Section C)*

Unpack the figurative or connotative meaning of the phrase. Ask: what associations does this image carry? What attitude does this word choice reveal?

One mark: The phrase suggests that [implied idea in own words], indicating that the writer believes [implied viewpoint].

Two marks: The phrase '[quotation]' implies [meaning of the image in own words]. This suggests the writer believes [viewpoint], because [brief reasoning from context].

Common Pitfalls — INFER

1. Lifting a sentence from the passage and presenting it as an inference — earns no marks.
2. Giving a personal opinion with no grounding in the passage.
3. Answering too literally when the question requires a figurative or emotional reading.
4. Stopping at the surface inference for a two-mark question — always push to a deeper layer.

Section B — TRAIT — Character Impression

TRAIT questions ask you to name a precise character trait — a stable quality of personality — revealed through the passage. The expected answer is an adjective or short phrase describing personality, not a description of what the character does. Vague adjectives (kind, nice, good, bad) earn no marks.

Character Trait Vocabulary

Category	Examples
Positive traits	resilient, tenacious, compassionate, magnanimous, pragmatic, empathetic, idealistic, perceptive
Negative traits	duplicitous, vindictive, obsequious, domineering, insecure, contemptuous, self-righteous, manipulative
Neutral traits	self-conscious, reserved, cautious, detached, introspective, methodical, impulsive

Question Type: TRAIT

Technique: Read the named paragraph, translate the character's actions and reactions into a precise trait adjective, and support each trait with brief evidence.

Step 1: Read the named paragraph, focusing on: what the character says, does, and how others react.

Step 2: Translate those behaviours into character traits. Ask: what kind of person acts this way?

Step 3: Choose the most precise adjective or phrase. Avoid generic descriptors.

Step 4: Support each trait with a brief piece of evidence from the passage.

Worked Example 1

Signal words: *What impression do you get of Alma from Paragraph 5? Support your answer with evidence from the paragraph.*

One trait (1 mark): [Character] is [precise adjective], as shown by [brief evidence in inverted commas or paraphrase].

Two traits (2 marks): Firstly, [character] is [trait 1], as shown by [evidence 1]. Secondly, [character] demonstrates [trait 2], as [evidence 2].

Impression format: The reader gets the impression that [character] is [trait], because [evidence-based reasoning about what the action or words reveal about personality].

Common Pitfalls — TRAIT

1. Using vague adjectives: 'nice', 'kind', 'good', 'bad', 'mean' — too imprecise to earn marks.
2. Describing what the character does rather than naming the trait it reveals.
3. Stating a trait with no supporting evidence from the text.
4. Selecting a trait that is not supported by the named paragraph.

Section C — MINDSET — State of Mind / Reaction

MINDSET questions ask you to identify a character's internal psychological or emotional state at a specific moment. They most commonly involve a figurative phrase that must be decoded. The figurative meaning must be expressed as an emotional or psychological state, not described literally.

Question Type: MINDSET

Technique: Determine whether the phrase is literal or figurative, then translate the figurative image into a precise emotional or psychological state.

Step 1: Read the phrase and determine: is it literal or figurative?

Step 2: If figurative, translate the image into its emotional or psychological meaning.

Step 3: Express that state in precise language — one word or one short phrase.

Step 4: If explanation is required, add one sentence connecting the image to the state of mind.

Worked Example 1

Signal words: What does the phrase 'rooted to the ground' tell us about Delia's reaction?

The phrase is figurative — 'rooted to the ground' does not mean she literally could not move. Translate the image: a tree rooted to the ground cannot move even if it tries. Applied to a person, this means paralysis caused by an overwhelming emotion.

Short answer: [Character] was [precise state, e.g. paralysed with shock / overwhelmed with awe / frozen with disbelief].

With explanation: This suggests that [character] was [state of mind], as the phrase implies [brief interpretation of the figurative image].

Common Pitfalls — MINDSET

1. Reading figurative language literally (e.g. interpreting 'rooted to the ground' as a description of physical inability to move rather than psychological paralysis).
2. Using vague emotional words: 'she was scared' — prefer 'she was immobilised by shock'.
3. Writing a long narrative account of the character's situation instead of identifying the specific state of mind.

Section D — STANCE — Writer's Attitude

STANCE questions ask you to identify the writer's stable, considered viewpoint towards a topic, group, policy, or idea as expressed throughout the passage or a named section. Distinguish this from tone (how the writer sounds in one specific section) and from a character's feeling (a transient personal emotion).

Attitude Vocabulary

Type	Examples
Critical / negative	dismissive, contemptuous, scornful, sceptical, deeply critical, disapproving, cynical
Positive / supportive	admiring, sympathetic, celebratory, enthusiastic, cautiously optimistic, respectful
Ambivalent	ambivalent, measured, balanced, guarded, reluctantly accepting

Question Type: STANCE

Technique: Re-read the named paragraph for the writer's evaluative language — loaded adjectives, ironic comments, emotive verbs — and select one precise attitude word.

Step 1: Re-read the named paragraph, focusing on evaluative language.

Step 2: Ask: does the writer endorse, criticise, question, or hold a balanced view of the topic?

Step 3: Choose one precise attitude word from the vocabulary bank.

Step 4: If explanation is required, cite specific word choice or phrasing as evidence.

Worked Example 1

Signal words: *What is the writer's attitude towards car owners as described in Paragraph 4? Give one word.*

Scan Paragraph 4 for evaluative language — words or phrases that carry judgement. Identify whether the writer endorses or criticises the subject.

One word: [Precise attitude word].

With explanation: The writer's attitude is [attitude word]. This is evident from [brief reference to specific phrasing], which conveys that [explanation of what this reveals about the writer's position].

Common Pitfalls — STANCE

1. Confusing attitude (stable viewpoint) with feeling (transient emotion), tone (manner of speaking), or mood (atmosphere).
2. Using vague attitude words: 'negative', 'positive' — prefer 'dismissive', 'admiring', 'deeply sceptical'.
3. Describing the topic rather than the writer's stance towards it.

Chapter 4

Technique: SWAP

Used for: DEFINE · REPHRASE

The SWAP technique is used whenever the question asks for the meaning of a word in context, or requires you to answer in your own words. The meaning of a word is determined by the context in which it appears, not by its dictionary definition. When 'in your own words' is specified, lifting from the passage scores zero. Every key content word — nouns, verbs, adjectives, adverbs — must be substituted with a shade-equivalent synonym.

The Shade-Equivalent Test

Original word	Acceptable synonym	Unacceptable — reason
hatred	animosity, intense hostility	dislike — too mild
consumed by grief	overwhelmed by deep sorrow	feeling sad — too weak
accumulated	gradually built up	got — wrong register
elated	overjoyed, exhilarated	happy — too weak
brittle	fragile, easily shattered	brittle — cannot reuse the word

Section A — DEFINE — Vocabulary in Context

DEFINE questions ask for the meaning of a specific word or phrase as it is used in this passage. The contextual meaning is what matters. The mark is not for the synonym alone; the contextual link — explaining how that meaning fits the passage — is required. Match the same part of speech as the original word.

Question Type: DEFINE

Technique: Re-read the target word and surrounding sentences, identify a shade-equivalent synonym, and anchor the definition to the passage context.

Step 1: Re-read the sentence containing the target word and the two or three surrounding sentences.

Step 2: Identify the part of speech. Your synonym must match the same part of speech.

Step 3: Think of a synonym that (a) has similar meaning and (b) fits the sentence grammatically.

Step 4: Check the shade: does your synonym capture the full emotional weight, not just a partial one?

Step 5: Write your answer: synonym + contextual link.

Worked Example 1

Signal words: *Explain the meaning of the word 'brittle' as used in line 14.*

Re-read the sentence and surrounding context to determine how 'brittle' is being used — physically, emotionally, or metaphorically.

One mark: [Word/phrase] means [synonym or paraphrase], suggesting that [brief contextual link to the passage].

Two marks: [Word/phrase] means [synonym]. In the context of the passage, it conveys [what this word choice reveals about the character, setting, or situation].

Worked Example 2

Signal words: *What does the phrase 'task fragmentation' mean as used in Paragraph 3? (Section C — non-fiction)*

For technical terms in non-fiction, define the term as the writer uses it in their argument, not as a general academic definition. Re-read the surrounding sentences for contextual clues.

One mark: '[Term]' means [paraphrase], referring in this context to [how the writer applies it in the argument].

Common Pitfalls — DEFINE

1. Giving only a dictionary definition with no link to how the term is used in the passage.
2. Selecting a synonym that does not match the same part of speech as the original word.
3. Choosing a synonym that is too weak or too strong in emotional weight.
4. Using the target word itself in the definition.
5. Defining only part of a compound phrase and ignoring the other part.

Section B — REPHRASE — In Your Own Words / Paraphrase

REPHRASE questions carry the explicit instruction 'in your own words', which means that lifting from the passage will score zero. Paraphrasing does not mean replacing one or two small words. You must substitute all key content words — nouns, verbs, adjectives, and adverbs that carry the meaning. Function words (the, a, of, and, to) do not need to be changed.

Question Type: REPHRASE

Technique: Identify every key content word, find a shade-equivalent synonym for each, and write a new sentence that preserves the original meaning without inverted commas.

Step 1: Locate the relevant section of the passage.

Step 2: Identify all key content words — nouns, verbs, adjectives, adverbs that carry meaning.

Step 3: For each key content word, generate a shade-equivalent synonym.

Step 4: Write your paraphrased answer. Do not use inverted commas.

Step 5: Re-read against the original. Check: has every key content word been replaced?

Worked Example 1

Signal words: *Explain in your own words what the writer thinks is unfair about the way Coach organises calisthenics. Use your own words.*

Locate the relevant passage. Identify the content words: 'unfair', 'organises', 'calisthenics', and any verbs or adjectives describing the coach's method. Substitute each one.

One point: [Paraphrased content entirely in own words — no inverted commas].

Two points: First, [paraphrased point 1]. Furthermore, [paraphrased point 2].

Common Pitfalls — REPHRASE

1. Leaving key content words unchanged while only replacing function words — scores zero.
2. Using inverted commas in your paraphrase — signals to the marker that you have quoted, not paraphrased.
3. Substituting with a synonym that softens or exaggerates the original meaning.
4. Changing so many words that the meaning is altered or distorted.

Chapter 5

Technique: QEE

Used for: EFFECT · ODDWORD · TONE · MOOD · CRAFT · QUOTES

The QEE technique — Quote, Explain, Effect — is the framework for all questions that ask how language creates a specific effect on the reader. It applies to six different question tags and is the most widely used technique in Paper 2. All three components must be present for every detail you discuss. Skipping any one component loses the mark for that detail.

Q–E–E Framework

Step	What to do
Quote	Select 2–5 words and place them in inverted commas. Do not quote a whole sentence — precision is rewarded.
Explain	In words different from the quotation, state what the word or device connotes or implies. Never reuse the quoted word in the explanation.
Effect	Explicitly link your explanation to the specific effect named in the question. This step is what separates a passage-specific answer from a generic one.

Common Literary and Rhetorical Devices

Device	What it does
Simile	Compares using 'like' or 'as'
Metaphor	States that something is something else
Personification	Gives non-human things human qualities
Oxymoron	Combines two contradictory ideas — key for ODDWORD
Paradox	A self-contradictory statement that is nonetheless true
Hyperbole	Deliberate exaggeration for ironic or emotional effect
Alliteration	Repeated initial consonant sounds
Onomatopoeia	Words that sound like what they describe
Rhetorical question	Implies a shared assumption; engages the reader directly
Short sentence	Creates abrupt emphasis, shock, or dramatic contrast
Repetition	Creates insistence, mounting tension, or emphasis
Direct address	Implicates the reader personally — key for EFFECT in non-fiction
Ellipsis	Creates suspense or a trailing, uncertain quality
Tricolon / list	Creates a sense of accumulation, excess, or completeness

Section A — EFFECT — Use of Language for Effect

EFFECT questions identify a specific effect and ask you to explain how the language achieves it. Two marks requires two genuinely distinct language details, each with its own explanation and effect link. Keep

quotations to 2–5 words.

Question Type: EFFECT

Technique: Apply Q–E–E for each detail. Each detail must target a different language feature and produce its own distinct explanation and effect link.

Step 1: Underline the stated effect in the question — this is your target for every explanation.

Step 2: Read the named paragraph and underline words or phrases that seem forceful or unusual.

Step 3: Select your first detail: quote it (2–5 words), explain the connotation, link to the effect.

Step 4: Select a second, different detail and repeat Q–E–E.

Step 5: Check: does each explanation connect to the named effect? Have you avoided reusing the quoted word?

Worked Example 1

Signal words: *Explain how the language in Paragraph 2 makes the storm seem like an aggressive person. Support your answer with two details.*

The stated effect is 'like an aggressive person'. Every explanation must connect to this.

Single detail (Q–E–E): The [device], '[short quotation]', suggests / conveys [what it implies in different words], which makes the storm seem [the stated effect].

Two details: First, the [device] '[quotation]' suggests [explanation 1], making the storm seem [effect]. Second, the [device] '[quotation]' connotes [explanation 2], reinforcing the impression that [effect].

Common Pitfalls — EFFECT

1. Feature-spotting: identifying the device without explaining its effect — scores zero.
2. Using the quoted word in the explanation (e.g. 'icy suggests something is icy') — circular explanation, scores zero.
3. Providing the same explanation for two different quotations.
4. Quoting too much — a long quotation suggests you cannot identify the exact words doing the work.
5. Forgetting to connect the explanation back to the specific effect named in the question.

Section B — ODDWORD — Unusual and Effective

ODDWORD questions target a specific word or phrase and require two separate sub-answers: (i) what is unusual about it, and (ii) what makes it effective. Each part must be answered in its own clearly labelled sentence. A single merged sentence is capped at 1 mark regardless of quality.

Question Type: ODDWORD

Technique: Identify the type of incongruity (oxymoron, paradox, or unexpected image), answer 'unusual' first in its own sentence, then answer 'effective' in a separate sentence.

Step 1: Read the highlighted phrase and identify the type of incongruity: oxymoron, paradox, or unexpected image.

Step 2: Unusual (1 mark): Write a sentence identifying the logical or semantic contradiction. Name the type of incongruity. Explain why the two ideas do not ordinarily go together.

Step 3: Effective (1 mark): Write a separate sentence explaining what the phrase achieves. What image, feeling, or idea does it create? Why is this better than a straightforward description?

Step 4: Check: are both answers in separate sentences?

Worked Example 1

Signal words: *What is (i) unusual and (ii) effective about the phrase 'motion within immobility' in line 23?*

The phrase combines 'motion' (movement) and 'immobility' (stillness) — two ideas that are logically contradictory. This makes it an oxymoron.

Unusual (separate sentence): This phrase is unusual because it combines [concept A] with [contradictory concept B] — concepts not ordinarily associated with one another — in the form of an oxymoron / paradox.

Effective (separate sentence): It is effective because it captures [specific idea / image / feeling], conveying [what this tells the reader] more vividly than a straightforward description would.

Common Pitfalls — ODDWORD

1. Merging both answers into a single sentence — limits the total to 1 mark.
2. Answering only the 'unusual' part or only the 'effective' part.
3. Simply naming the device ('it is an oxymoron') without explaining what is unusual about it.
4. Vague effectiveness answers such as 'it makes the reader think' — specify what the reader thinks and why.

Section C — TONE — Tone of Voice

Tone is the attitude of the writer or speaker as revealed through word choice and phrasing. It is different from mood (atmosphere for the reader), attitude (stable viewpoint), and feeling (a character's emotion). TONE questions require one precise tone word; imprecise words (sad, happy, angry) earn no marks.

Tone Vocabulary

Type	Examples
Negative / critical	sarcastic, ironic, dismissive, indignant, contemptuous, scornful, exasperated, sardonic, bitter
Reflective / wistful	nostalgic, wistful, melancholic, resigned, elegiac, reflective
Authoritative	urgent, cautionary, measured, detached, impassioned, condescending, assured
Sympathetic	sympathetic, reverent, hopeful, compassionate, mournful

Question Type: TONE

Technique: Re-read the named lines carefully and ask how the speaker or writer sounds — what attitude their word choices convey. Select one precise tone word.

Step 1: Re-read the named lines or comment very carefully.

Step 2: Ask: how does the speaker or writer sound? What attitude do the word choices convey?

Step 3: Do not confuse the speaker's tone with the character's feeling or the atmosphere of the scene.

Step 4: Select one precise tone word from the vocabulary bank.

Step 5: If explanation is required, support with a specific word or phrase from the text.

Worked Example 1

Signal words: *What is the tone of the brother's comment in lines 18–19? Give one word.*

Re-read the comment. Focus on the word choices — what do they reveal about the speaker's attitude? Is the speaker mocking, pitying, angry, wistful?

One-word answer: [Precise tone word].

With explanation: The tone is [tone word]. This is conveyed through '[specific word or phrase]', which suggests [brief explanation of what the word choice reveals about the speaker's attitude].

Common Pitfalls — TONE

1. Confusing tone (speaker's attitude) with mood (atmosphere for the reader).
2. Confusing tone with a character's feeling (e.g. writing 'she feels sad' when the question asks for the tone of her voice).
3. Using imprecise tone words: 'sad', 'happy', 'angry' — prefer 'melancholic', 'elated', 'indignant'.
4. Giving two tone words when only one is asked for.

Section D — MOOD — Mood / Atmosphere

Mood (also called atmosphere) is the prevailing emotional feeling the passage creates in the reader. It is not the speaker's or writer's attitude (that is tone) and it is not a character's personal emotion (that is feeling). Mood is about the effect on the reader, created through setting, imagery, pacing, and language choices.

Mood Vocabulary

Examples	ominous, elegiac, frenetic, unsettling, serene, oppressive, eerie, foreboding, desolate, tranquil, claustrophobic, whimsical, melancholic, tense, hopeful, wistful
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Question Type: MOOD

Technique: Re-read the named paragraph for descriptions of place, time, light, sound, and weather. Ask what emotional feeling these descriptions produce in the reader, then select one precise mood word.

Step 1: Re-read the named paragraph, focusing on the physical environment and sensory details.

Step 2: Ask: what emotional feeling does this description produce in the reader? Not the character — the reader.

Step 3: Select one precise mood word.

Step 4: Support with a brief quotation from the passage that creates that mood.

Worked Example 1

Signal words: *What mood is created in Paragraph 1? Support your answer with one word or phrase from the paragraph.*

Re-read the paragraph for setting details — descriptions of light, sound, weather, or space. Identify the emotional atmosphere these details create in a reader.

One-word answer: [Mood word].

With support: The mood is [mood word], created by '[short quotation]', which makes the reader feel [brief explanation of the emotional effect].

Common Pitfalls — MOOD

1. Confusing mood (atmosphere for the reader) with tone (speaker's attitude) or a character's emotion.
2. Using imprecise mood words: 'sad', 'scary' — prefer 'melancholic', 'ominous'.
3. Describing the content of the paragraph rather than the emotional atmosphere it creates.

Section E — CRAFT — Technical Writer's Craft

CRAFT questions target a specific writing technique and ask what effect it creates on the reader. The technique is often already named in the question. Your task is to explain the effect of that technique — not to describe what the lines say. Describing content instead of technique is the most common error on this question type.

Question Type: CRAFT

Technique: Name the technique clearly, explain what it does to the reader, and connect both to the subject matter of the passage.

Step 1: Re-read the named lines and identify the technique described in the question.

Step 2: Think about the effect of that technique on the reader — not what the lines say, but what the technique does.

Step 3: Name the technique in your answer, explain the effect, then link to the subject or character.

Step 4: For two-mark answers, identify two distinct effects of the same technique, or two techniques.

Worked Example 1

Signal words: *What effect does the writer create by using a short sentence followed by a longer one in lines 30–31?*

The technique (short sentence followed by a longer one) is already named. Focus entirely on what this technique does to the reader.

One mark: The writer uses [technique] to [effect, e.g. create a sharp, abrupt emphasis], which conveys [link to character or subject].

Two marks: First, [technique 1] creates [effect 1], suggesting [link]. Second, [technique 2] conveys [effect 2], emphasising [link].

Common Pitfalls — CRAFT

1. Describing what the lines say (content) instead of what the technique does (effect).
2. Naming the technique without explaining its effect on the reader.
3. Giving a vague effect: 'it makes the writing more interesting' — specify how and why.

Section F — QUOTES — Inverted Commas / Scare Quotes

When a writer in a non-fiction text places inverted commas around a word, they are almost never using them for ordinary quotation or emphasis. They are signalling irony, sarcasm, scepticism, or distancing. The most common incorrect answer is: 'the inverted commas emphasise the word'. This is wrong. Inverted commas never simply emphasise.

Four Effects of Inverted Commas in Non-Fiction

Effect	Meaning
Irony	The writer says one thing but means the opposite
Sarcasm	A cutting or hostile version of irony
Scepticism	The writer doubts the validity of the term or claim
Distancing	The writer signals that others use this term but the writer rejects or questions it

Question Type: QUOTES

Technique: Identify the standard meaning of the word, then explain how the writer uses it differently and name the effect: irony, sarcasm, scepticism, or distancing.

Step 1: Look at the word in inverted commas and identify its standard dictionary meaning.

Step 2: Ask: is the writer using this word sincerely or critically?

Step 3: Identify the effect: irony, sarcasm, scepticism, or distancing.

Step 4: Explain what the writer actually implies by placing the word in inverted commas.

Worked Example 1

Signal words: *Why do you think the writer puts inverted commas around the word 'planted' in line 22?*

Identify the standard meaning of 'planted' (placed deliberately in the ground). Ask: is the writer using this sincerely, or is there a gap between the standard meaning and the reality being described?

One mark: The writer places '[word]' in inverted commas to signal [irony / sarcasm / scepticism / distancing], suggesting that [what the writer actually implies].

Two marks: The word '[word]' normally means [standard meaning]. However, by placing it in inverted commas, the writer signals [effect], implying that [the gap between the word's conventional meaning and the reality the writer is describing].

Common Pitfalls — QUOTES

1. Saying the inverted commas 'emphasise' the word — this is always wrong.
2. Treating the inverted commas as direct speech (as if the writer is simply quoting someone else).
3. Failing to explain what the writer actually implies — the answer must go beyond naming the technique.
4. Choosing the wrong effect: distinguish between irony (general), sarcasm (hostile), scepticism (doubt), and distancing (rejection of a term).

Chapter 6

Technique: BUILD

Used for: PROVE · CONTRAST · DEFEND · DEBATE

The BUILD technique is used whenever the question asks you to select evidence and use it to support, justify, or adjudicate a specific claim. It is more demanding than SCAN because explanation or paraphrasing is also required alongside the evidence. A quotation alone earns no marks; an explanation alone earns no marks. Both must be present.

Core Method

- Step 1:** Identify the claim or position that must be supported or adjudicated.
- Step 2:** Locate evidence in the named paragraph or line range only — do not go outside it.
- Step 3:** Paraphrase the evidence in your own words unless direct quoting is explicitly required.
- Step 4:** Explain how each piece of evidence connects to the claim.
- Step 5:** Present each unit as a clearly separated point: First... / Second... / Third...

Section A — PROVE — Three-Piece Evidence Explanation

PROVE questions ask you to find three distinct pieces of evidence from the named paragraph and pair each with its own individual explanation. The explanation must not reuse the content word from the quotation — circular explanations score zero. The three units must cover three genuinely distinct points.

Question Type: PROVE

Technique: For each of three distinct evidence points: quote (2–5 words), then explain in own words how that piece supports the claim. No shared explanations.

- Step 1:** Read the claim in the question carefully before going to the paragraph.
- Step 2:** Read the named paragraph and identify four or five candidate pieces of evidence.
- Step 3:** Select the strongest three that are clearly distinct from each other.
- Step 4:** For each: write a short quotation in inverted commas, then immediately write its explanation in different words.
- Step 5:** Present the three units as: First... / Second... / Third...

Worked Example 1

Signal words: *The writer claims that she had had 'the best workout ever' (line 41). Explain how this claim is supported with reference to three pieces of evidence from Paragraph 6.*

First unit: First, '[short quotation]' shows that [own-words explanation of how this supports the claim].

Second unit: Second, '[short quotation]' demonstrates that [own-words explanation].

Third unit: Third, '[short quotation]' suggests that [own-words explanation], which supports the claim that [brief restatement of the claim in own words].

Common Pitfalls — PROVE

1. Three quotations under one combined explanation — each unit requires its own individual explanation.
2. Circular explanation: repeating the content word from the quotation in the explanation (e.g. 'breathless shows she was breathless').
3. Using evidence from outside the named paragraph.
4. Using three evidence points that all refer to the same underlying idea.

Section B — CONTRAST — Identify the Contrast

CONTRAST questions ask you to identify and articulate two opposing ideas, settings, or conditions. You must state both sides clearly — providing only one side earns at most half-marks. Always check the question word: 'what is the contrast' asks for content; 'how is the contrast created' asks for technique. These require different answer types.

Question Type: CONTRAST

Technique: Locate both sides of the contrast in the named paragraph, state each side clearly, and link them with a contrast connector.

Step 1: Identify what is being contrasted in the question (e.g. inside vs outside, past vs present).

Step 2: Locate both sides of the contrast in the named paragraph.

Step 3: Clearly state Side A: what is its quality, atmosphere, or condition?

Step 4: Clearly state Side B: what is the contrasting quality, atmosphere, or condition?

Step 5: Use a contrast connector: whereas, while, in contrast, however, unlike.

Worked Example 1

Signal words: *In Paragraph 8, what is the contrast between the atmosphere inside the library and outside in the street?*

Locate the description of the library interior and the street exterior in Paragraph 8. Identify the quality or atmosphere of each.

Full answer: Inside the library, [description of Side A — e.g. the atmosphere was calm and orderly], whereas outside in the street, [description of Side B — e.g. it was noisy and chaotic].

Alternative: While [Side A is characterised by X], [Side B is characterised by Y], creating a sharp contrast between [what the two sides represent].

Common Pitfalls — CONTRAST

1. Stating only one side of the contrast — maximum half-marks.
2. Answering how the contrast is created (technique) when the question only asks what the contrast is (content).
3. Using a weak or vague contrast that does not clearly reflect an opposition.

Section C — DEFEND — Justification Question

DEFEND questions ask you to find and articulate the textual basis for defending a specific claim. You are not asked whether you personally agree with the claim. You are asked to identify and paraphrase the evidence that supports or defends it, as if building the case for it.

Question Type: DEFEND

Technique: Locate evidence in the named paragraph that defends — not contradicts — the claim. Paraphrase it and frame it as a justification.

Step 1: Identify the claim that needs to be justified.

Step 2: Return to the named paragraph and look for evidence that supports the claim.

Step 3: Paraphrase that evidence in your own words — do not lift.

Step 4: Frame your answer as a justification: 'The [party] could argue that...'

Step 5: Check: are you defending the claim, not questioning or dismissing it?

Worked Example 1

Signal words: *The writer says the dinosaurs in the film 'are far from scientifically accurate'. With reference to Paragraph 1, how could the filmmakers justify this?*

Look for evidence in Paragraph 1 that could be used to defend the filmmakers' choice — not evidence that supports the writer's criticism.

One mark: This could be justified by pointing out that [paraphrased evidence from the named paragraph].

Two marks: The [filmmakers] could justify this by arguing, first, that [paraphrased evidence 1] and, second, that [paraphrased evidence 2], both of which support the claim that [brief restatement in own words].

Common Pitfalls — DEFEND

1. Disagreeing with or questioning the claim instead of justifying it.
2. Lifting verbatim from the passage instead of paraphrasing.
3. Using evidence from outside the named paragraph.

Section D — DEBATE — Two-Students Question

DEBATE questions present two student viewpoints and ask which is better supported by a specific line range. You must read both positions carefully, find the evidence in the named lines, commit to one position, and give a clear, decided answer. Do not give a balanced response when 'better supported' is asked.

Question Type: DEBATE

Technique: Read both positions, locate supporting evidence in the named lines, commit to one position, paraphrase the evidence, and explain the connection.

- Step 1:** Read both student positions carefully. Clearly understand what each claims.
- Step 2:** Turn to the named line range and read it carefully, looking for evidence for each position.
- Step 3:** Decide which position the evidence better supports. Commit to one answer.
- Step 4:** Paraphrase the relevant evidence in your own words. Do not lift.
- Step 5:** State clearly whose view is better supported, then explain why using two or three pieces of paraphrased evidence.

Worked Example 1

Signal words: *Su Lin says car users are more responsible for reducing pollution. Ahmed says manufacturers are. Using lines 14–22, explain whose view is better supported.*

Read lines 14–22 carefully. Identify which position the evidence in those lines directly supports. Commit to one student's view.

Standard (3 marks): [Student A's / B's] view is better supported. In lines [X–Y], the writer states that [paraphrased evidence 1] and that [paraphrased evidence 2]. This supports [Student A's / B's] position that [restatement], because [explanation of the link].

With contrast: While [Student A] argues [position], the passage more strongly supports [Student B's] view by showing that [paraphrased evidence 1] and [paraphrased evidence 2], both of which suggest that [conclusion].

Common Pitfalls — DEBATE

1. Giving a personal opinion about who is right instead of identifying the textual support.
2. Mixing up the two students' positions.
3. Lifting verbatim instead of paraphrasing the evidence.

4. Giving a balanced answer when the question asks which view is better supported — choose one.

Chapter 7

Technique: WH-CHECK

Used for: WHY/HOW · and as a discipline across all techniques

WH-CHECK is both a standalone technique for the WHY/HOW question type and a discipline that must be applied before answering every question in Paper 2. WHY and HOW are not interchangeable. Answering a WHY question with a technique description, or a HOW question with a reason, guarantees zero marks. SEAB examiners consistently identify this as the leading cause of avoidable mark loss across both sections.

WHY vs HOW — The Essential Distinction

Question word	Asks for	Answer pattern	Answer begins with
WHY	Reason / purpose / motivation / causation / intent	Explain why the writer made this choice and what it achieves in the argument	'Because...' / 'In order to...'
HOW	Method / technique / mechanism / craft	Name the technique, quote it briefly, and explain its effect on the reader	'By using...' / 'Through...' / 'By [verb]-ing...'

Question Type: WHY/HOW

Technique: Underline the question word before writing. Check that the opening of your answer matches: WHY answers begin with 'Because' or 'In order to'; HOW answers begin with 'By using' or 'Through'.

Step 1: Underline WHY or HOW in the question.

Step 2: If WHY: identify the writer's reason or purpose. Ask: why does the writer make this choice?

Step 3: If HOW: identify the technique or device. Ask: by what means does the writer achieve this effect?

Step 4: Check the opening word of your answer against the question word before writing the full answer.

Worked Example 1

Signal words: *Why does the writer refer to 'empathy and compassion' in Paragraph 6?*

This is a WHY question — it asks for a reason or purpose, not a technique.

WHY answer: The writer refers to [quotation] in order to [reason / purpose — what the writer wants the reader to think or feel], highlighting that [what this achieves in the context of the argument].

Worked Example 2

Signal words: *How does the writer create a sense of urgency in Paragraph 3?*

This is a HOW question — it asks for a technique, not a reason.

HOW answer: The writer creates a sense of urgency by using [technique — e.g. a series of short, fragmented sentences / urgent imperatives / direct address], which [explains the effect of this technique on the reader].

Common Pitfalls — WHY/HOW

1. Answering a WHY question with a technique description.
2. Answering a HOW question with a reason or purpose.
3. Writing a combined WHY-and-HOW answer when only one is asked for.
4. Treating WHY and HOW as interchangeable — they are not.

Chapter —

Quick-Reference Card

Tag → Technique → Opening sentence structure

Use this card as a revision tool. Cover the right-hand column and practise recalling the technique and sentence starter for each tag from memory.

Tag	Technique	Opening sentence structure
LIFT	SCAN	"[Exact phrase]." / First, [detail 1]. Second, [detail 2].
SPOT	SCAN	One example is "[detail 1]". Another example is "[detail 2]".
FIND	SCAN	"[Single word / exact phrase from passage]."
INFER	DEDUCE	This suggests that [character] felt / was [inference in own words].
TRAIT	DEDUCE	[Character] is [precise adjective], as shown by [evidence].
MINDSET	DEDUCE	[Character] was [psychological state in own words].
STANCE	DEDUCE	The writer's attitude is [precise attitude word], as evident from [word choice].
DEFINE	SWAP	[Word] means [synonym], suggesting that [contextual link].
REPHRASE	SWAP	First, [paraphrased point 1]. Furthermore, [paraphrased point 2].
EFFECT	QEE	The [device] '[quotation]' suggests [explanation], which creates [effect].
ODDWORD	QEE	It is unusual because [incongruity]. It is effective because [effect on reader].
TONE	QEE	The tone is [tone word], conveyed through '[quotation]', which suggests [explanation].
MOOD	QEE	The mood is [mood word], created by '[quotation]', which makes the reader feel [explanation].
CRAFT	QEE	The writer uses [technique] to [effect], which conveys [link to subject].
QUOTES	QEE	'[Word]' normally means [standard meaning]; the inverted commas signal [irony / scepticism / distancing], implying that [what the writer actually means].
PROVE	BUILD	First, '[quotation]' shows that [explanation]. Second... Third...
CONTRAST	BUILD	[Side A] is [quality], whereas [Side B] is [contrasting quality].
DEFEND	BUILD	This could be justified by pointing out that [paraphrased evidence].
DEBATE	BUILD	[Student X's] view is better supported. The passage states that [paraphrased evidence].
WHY/HOW	WH-CHECK	WHY: ...in order to [reason]. HOW: ...by using [technique], which [effect].